Spanner skidded across the deck of *The Trashbringer*, grabbing at the tiny, naked goblin darting between crates and consoles. “Bean! Seriously! STOP!”

Kiria lunged from the opposite side, arms flailing. “Spanner, I’ve got… oh no, he’s behind the engine manifold again!”

Bean squealed with delight, twisting and somersaulting like he had springs in his legs. “Catch me if you can!”

Arlo Haegue’s calm, steady voice cut through the chaos over ship-wide comms. “Spanner. Kiria. Item secured. Get launch ready. You have five minutes. Do not waste them.”

Lyra’s voice followed, smooth but sharp. “No delays. The launch cannot wait, and neither can we. Bean stays in one place, clothed or otherwise, until the drive is engaged. Hurry we have company on our tails!”

Spanner froze mid-lunge, staring at the giggling whirlwind. “Five… minutes?!”

Lyra’s sigh hissed through the speakers. “Yes. Now move… or I will ensure the launch is engaged without you.”

“Kira, get to the pilot's seat, I'll get Bean.” Then Spanner lunged again while Kiria darted to the front of the ship. Bean darted under a console, over the fuel injectors, and somehow scrambled up a pipe along the ceiling.

The ship’s engines thrummed, vibrating the deck. Sparks flickered from a panel Kiria had knocked loose earlier. *The Trashbringer* shuddered, as nervous as its crew.

Spanner made one last desperate grab. His hands closed around Bean mid-somersault. The goblin wriggled and kicked for a tense heartbeat, then Spanner dumped him into the containment pod near engineering. The lid hissed shut.

Bean sat up, huffing, arms crossed. “I… I wasn’t ready!”

Spanner dropped into a seat beside the pod, panting. “You’re… contained. Finally.”

Behind them, boots pounded. Arlo and Lyra burst up the cargo bay ramp, the massive yellow crystal floating a step behind Lyra, tethered by a thin, crackling energy leash. It shimmered violently with sparks of green, violet, and red twisting like liquid fire inside.

And behind *them*… the Kree`Na`Ma.

The creature was enormous, floating above the deck, hundreds of writhing tentacles extending downward like ropes of nightmare made flesh. Vast elephantine ears flared. Tusks gleamed like ivory towers. It loomed, utterly unconcerned with walls or guns.

Spanner slammed the ramp’s close button, yelling into comms over the roar of engines and distant weapons fire.

“Go! GO GO GO! Holy shit, go, it’s a Kree`Na`Ma!”

Kiria’sr hands blurred across controls, grav-locks releasing, main drive spooling, jump sequence initializing. Readouts flared red and amber. “Engines hot in ten! Arlo, get that crystal locked to the deck NOW!”

Arlo nodded, straining as he and Lyra hauled the glowing prize toward the reinforced cargo clamps. The crystal pulsed brighter with every step, casting prismatic light across the cargo bay like sun lit storm clouds.

The Kree`Na`Ma surged. Tentacles lashed toward the hull, clang-clang-clang. One slammed against the dorsal armor terrifying strength bending it slightly.

Spanner vaulted into the weapons station. “Guns online!”

Twin top mounted plasma turrets turned around and spat sun hot fire at the beast that did little more than anger it while pushing it backward. Kinetic slugs from point defense turrets carved glowing trenches through writhing flesh. Chunks vaporized. Severed tentacles burst into black mist… then knit back together almost instantly.

The Kree`Na`Ma shrieked, a psychic knife through every skull, but it slowed. Just enough.
Kiria shoved the throttle forward.

“Ramp sealed! Punching out!”

The Trashbringer groaned as the main drives ignited, engulfing the beast in flame. Deck plates rattled teeth. Flames and plasma spilled from the thrusters. The ship lurched, blasting upward rolling Bean around in his pod giggling, Arlo and Lyra holding onto whatever they could grab for dear life. One massive tentacle stretched after them, impossibly long, only for the aft turret to slice it clean away. The limb fell, writhing, then flashed into regenerative energy.

Bean poked his head up in the pod, eyes wide. “It… it’s still out there!”

Spanner gripped the rail, g-forces pinning him. “Yeah, kid. And it’s pissed.”

Kiria kept her focus on the sky, hands steady despite the shaking ship. “Main drive spooling. Course locked. Active camo engaged. Three… two… one…”

The engines raged as the junk planet was left behind. The hangar, the Kree`Na`Ma, the chaos, all smeared into blinding white light and vanished.

“Somehow… we survived,” Spanner slumped against the weapons console, breathing hard.

Bean glared up at him, indignant. “You cheated! I almost won!”

Kiria leaned back in the pilot chair, wiping sweat. “Therapy. We’re all getting therapy.”

From the cargo bay, Lyra’s voice drifted, cool, faintly amused. “The crystal is secure. Everything else is negotiable.”

Arlo appeared in the doorway, brushing dust from his jacket, calm as ever.

“Next time, we sedate the child *before* a heist.”

Spanner snorted. “Next time, maybe we don’t steal from a regenerating tentacled god.”

Bean banged on the pod lid. “I want snacks!”

Everyone groaned in unison. *The Trashbringer* streaked into the black, one strange crystal, one very contained bean, and four very tired criminals aboard, its shadow lingering in every reflection, a reminder that this was only the beginning.

The Trashbringer floated silently in low orbit, hull shadowed against the pale curve of the planet below. Stealth mode engaged, engines idling, they drifted in the hush of space. In the back of the ship, the crew gathered, eyes fixed on the massive crystal now secured in the hover cradle. Even Bean, finally dressed and subdued, stared up at it, awe written across his small face.

Kiria lifted him slightly so he could get a better view. "That there," she said, voice low but steady, "is a System Seed Crystal. It’s what brings the System to new worlds."

Bean’s eyes widened, his tiny hands resting against the cradle’s protective barrier.

Arlo stepped closer, gaze sharp as ever. "I know I already asked, but stealth is engaged, right? And it’s working?"

Kiria rolled her eyes, amused. "Yes, yes, it’s engaged. Trying to have a moment with my kid?"

Arlo’s expression softened. "Sorry."

Lyra laughed, a musical sound cutting through the tension. "So bossy."

Kiria stuck her tongue out at Lyra, unrepentant. Spanner, finally able to relax a fraction, reached out and placed a hand on the cradle. "Man… you can *feel* the energy emanating from it. Like it’s alive."

Arlo’s attention snapped back to business. "Okay. How long till the next rail launch?"

Spanner glanced at the ship’s chrono display. "About thirty ticks. We should slip into position so it can mask our exit."

Lyra’s tone shifted, clipped and efficient. "Okay, everyone, suit up. You too, Bean."

Bean’s pout deepened, arms crossed. "Do I *have* to?"

"This is going to be a high-G push," Lyra said, voice firm. "Only way out of this prison. One shot. Get ready."

Arlo looked at the crystal one last time, its golden glow casting prismatic light across their faces. "Let’s make it count."

The crew moved with precision now, the tension of the previous chase still humming in their veins. Even Bean, reluctantly strapping into his small suit, couldn’t hide the thrill in his eyes.

Silence settled for a heartbeat, broken only by the hum of the engines and the distant shimmer of the trash covered planet below. Everyone knew what came next: speed, risk, and the fragile hope that this one push would carry them free.

The Trashbringer trembled as it aligned with the rail launcher, engines humming beneath stealth mode. The crew was strapped in, faces tense behind their visors, fingers clenched on rails and controls. Even Bean’s tiny suit was snug and sealed, though his eyes flicked from the massive crystal to the looming structure of the trash planet like he was watching a monster rise from the depths.

Lyra’s voice cut sharply through the comms. "Hold on. Engines at maximum. Crystal at hover stability. Everyone braced."

Kiria’s hands were steady on the console, guiding the ship into the precise corridor where the launcher’s trajectory would intersect. Spanner gripped the edge of the deck, knuckles white, muttering something incomprehensible under his breath.

"Here we go," Arlo said, voice calm but tense, eyes flicking to the crystal. "High-G push in… three… two… one…"

The rail launcher fired. A massive chunk of compressed metals, shot upward into low orbit, igniting the outer layers of the trash with sparks and molten fragments.

The Trashbringer lurched violently, the sudden acceleration pressing everyone into their harnesses. The G-forces pulled at their suits, faces pressed into visors as inertial dampeners struggled to compensate. Even Spanner’s wild shouting was reduced to a strangled scream.

Outside, the ship skimmed alongside the massive propellant of metals, the debris cloud serving as a temporary shield. Each chunk of scrap glinted in the faint sunlight of orbit, spinning slowly, a dangerous ballet of jagged metal. The Kree`na`ma, or any other threat lurking below, would see only a blur.

Bean’s small voice squeaked from behind his visor. "Again!!… so fast!"

Kiria’s grin was tight. "One way trip, kid. Stay strapped."

The crystal hovered at Lyra’s side, its golden light rippling as if in sync with the ship’s movements, humming faintly, stabilizing pulses, whispering the subtle rhythm of power. Arlo monitored every sensor, every tremor, ensuring they didn’t drift off course or trigger the orbital defenses.

The debris launched ahead, acting as both shield and decoy, masking their subtle signatures from the prison’s sensors. Every second felt like an eternity, every minor jolt threatening to fling them into the void.

Then, slowly, excruciatingly, the Trashbringer cleared the shielded orbit. The lump of metals glinted one last time before slipping below them. The planet, its defenses, its horrors, all of it, receded beneath the stealth-tinged shadow of the Trashbringer.

The G-forces eased. The ship hummed, gliding smoothly now, invisibly, silently. Everyone exhaled. Even Bean, still clinging to his pod restraints, managed a small, awed whistle.

Arlo unclenched his jaw. "We made it."

Lyra’s laugh was quiet but triumphant. "Close… but not *dead* close."

Spanner sagged to the floor, muttering, "I… never… ever…"

Kiria rolled her eyes, hands still on the console. "One day, Spanner, you’ll learn to enjoy the ride. Be more like Bean!"

Outside the viewport, the stars stretched endlessly. The Trashbringer moved through the darkness like a ghost, carrying its precious crystal, a pile of goblins, and two of the most dangerous travelers they’d ever met, alive, unseen, and still very much in control.

The Trashbringer drifted silently through the void, stealth mode still engaged. The glow of the System Seed Crystal filled the rear cabin with soft golden light, casting long, dancing shadows across the crew. For the first time since the Kree`na`ma chase, everyone could breathe. Even Bean, now fully suited and buckled into a seat, sat wide-eyed, staring at the crystal as if it had swallowed the whole universe.

Kiria leaned against the console, fingers idly tracing the readouts. "So… our next stop?" she asked, voice low, almost conversational.

Arlo’s eyes were on the navigation feed, calculating trajectories with meticulous precision. "Earth," he said. Flat. Certain.

Spanner groaned from where he slumped against a bulkhead. "Earth? That’s… your homeworld right Arlo?"

Lyra chuckled, brushing a strand of hair from her face. "A long year in pretend-trash mode before we even touch FTL engines. They won’t notice us drifting out toward the outer solar system."

Arlo nodded. "Yeah, Earth is home. And it needs this crystal. We masquerade as debris, propelled slowly outward by the prison’s mass launchers. That keeps our signature low. Calculations say roughly one year until we can fire the FTL engines and actually leave this system safely."

Kiria’s gaze drifted to the crystal, still hovering beside Lyra. "That will leave one year for them right? That’s plenty of time for people to get off-world, if the plans hold."

Bean piped up, tiny voice incredulous. "A *whole year*? That’s forever!"

"Long enough to matter," Lyra said softly, giving him a small smile.

Spanner rubbed his eyes. "So, we’re basically a giant piece of space junk for a year? Then we spend months taking the drift lanes to earth then get there in time for them to have a year to learn the system and maybe it can help them get off the planet before it’s destroyed."

Arlo allowed a small smirk. "Yup that’s it in a nutshell." His gaze hardened. "We try to save as many as we can."

Kiria nodded, crossing her arms. "Then let’s make every second count. Earth isn’t going to wait for us."

Silence fell for a beat as the crew let the reality sink in. One year of drifting, hiding, preparing. One year to position themselves, to stay unnoticed, and to give the people of Earth a fighting chance.

Bean, still staring at the crystal, finally whispered, "It’s… really big."

"Yeah," Arlo said, voice softer now, almost reverent. "Ok, time for snacks I think."

“SNACKSSSS!” Bean wiggled in joy.

Outside, the stars stretched infinitely, unchanging and silent. Inside, the Trashbringer moved with purpose, carrying its precious cargo, and its fragile, determined crew, toward a planet that needed them more than they could yet imagine.